the feature had been abandoned, while in Dirang Dzong Kaul said he had agreed to a withdrawal but he had no idea to where; this now left 48 Brigade in Bomdila, commanded by Brigadier Gurbax Singh as the last line of defence.

After Kaul's return from Walong the previous evening, the initial focus had been on Se-la and Dirang Dzong. After the cancellation of the withdrawal order and the dispatch of a new signal telling 4 Division to hold its position, the corps commander had been briefed on the developments in and around Bomdila. The order pertaining to the pullback from Thembang the moment the Chinese appeared indicated that the withdrawal syndrome had also affected Gurbax.

Thembang was perhaps the ideal location to hold as artillery guns positioned further down the road towards Bomdila could create major problems for the Chinese. From a tactical point of view, it was imperative that the Thembang Ridge be reoccupied without any delay. A call was put through to commander 48 Brigade at around 9.30 p.m. Before Kaul could say anything, Gurbax Singh (the son of Sir Teja Singh who built Lutyens' Delhi and the younger brother of the celebrated writer Khushwant Singh) said that 5 Guards could no longer be contacted. The battalion seemed to have disintegrated. There was no question of pushing fresh troops to Thembang because, according to Gurbax, the Chinese had already cut off the approach from Bomdila.

Kaul was intent on re-establishing the line of communication between Bomdila and Dirang. He ordered Gurbax to activate the 7 Cavalry troop of Stewart tanks at Bomdila and lead an infantry column and destroy the Chinese roadblock. For tanks to head off into the dark looking for roadblocks was madness, but obviously Gurbax could not say that to his corps commander. In Burma, the British had evolved techniques to break Japanese roadblocks, but these methods needed fine-tuning and extensive practice. Gurbax protested that it was too dark and he did not want to deplete Bomdila's defences any further.

Not one to be bothered with technical details, the corps commander insisted that a fighting column should step out and patrol the Bomdila–Dirang Dzong road immediately. When Gurbax hesitated, Kaul ordered the brigade commander to move immediately. Kaul reasoned that it was vital to attack the Chinese right away for it was highly unlikely that the blocks were held in strength at this point in time. He also assured Gurbax that he was